Questions to Ask the People Who Help Your Mother, the People Who Could, and Her Doctor and Pharmacist

Fifteen questions, sorted by who can answer them, with room to write what they say.

Each of these people knows a different part of your mother's week. Bring the questions written down, ask them when there's an easy moment, and write the answer under each one.

This guide doesn't answer the questions and doesn't say which matters most. Nobody is being asked to commit to anything. You're finding out how things stand.

Your mother

It's her week, so start with her. Write what she says the way she says it.

1. Here is the week as we've written it down: who comes by, who calls, who drives. What have we missed or got wrong?

2. If one of us couldn't come for a while, who would you be comfortable having instead?

The people who help now

Your sister with the Tuesday drive, the neighbor who looks in most mornings, anyone with a regular day or a standing job.

1. What do you do for her in an ordinary week, and on which days?

2. How is it going on your end? Do the day and the time still suit you?

3. Is anything coming up in your own life that might change when you can help?

4. When you can't make it, what happens now?

5. Have you noticed anything you weren't sure whether to mention?

The people who could

A relative, a friend or another neighbor who hasn't been asked. These are questions, not requests, and “I'd rather not” is a full answer.

1. If the Tuesday drive or the morning look-in ever needed covering for a week, is that something you'd be open to in principle?

2. What would you be comfortable doing, and what wouldn't you?

Her doctor

At a routine visit, with your mother there or with her say-so.

1. Here are a few things we've noticed: her balance, how she gets around, a health concern that keeps coming up. Which of them would you like to look at?

2. Have you given her any instructions that the people who help her should know about?

3. Here is when someone is with her in an ordinary week and when she is on her own. Is there anything in that you'd like to talk through with us?

Her pharmacist

With your mother there or with her say-so, the same as with her doctor.

1. Here is what we've noticed about how her medications go in an ordinary week. Is there anything you'd like to review with her?

Your care consultant

Someone whose work is to look at the whole picture with the family.

1. Here are the things around the house that we've seen or she has mentioned. Who should each of them go to?

2. Given the week we've written down and the concerns on our list, what else would you want to know?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions or put them in order. What an answer means for your mother's week is for her, the family and the professionals who know her to work out together.

Ready for the next step?

You have your questions sorted by who can answer them, and soon some answers. The care interview gives those answers somewhere to go: it walks you through your mother's situation area by area and turns what you've learned into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The question about what a possible helper would and wouldn't be comfortable doing follows a question AARP's planning guide suggests family members consider. Including her pharmacist follows MedlinePlus, which suggests families get to know the pharmacist. The grouping by role is ours.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Caregiving - medication management: MedlinePlus Medical Encyclopedia